

IELTS Writing: Stuck at 6.5 Pack

Book 6 · Break the score plateau with clear, fixable changes

Stratum IELTS · stratumielts.com

Edition 2026 · Original content

Part of the Stratum IELTS Writing Guide Series

Who this book is for

You can write 250 words.

You know the essay “shape”.

But your score stays **6.0–6.5** and does not move.

This book targets that exact pain: **not beginners, not Band 8 writers — stuck middle scorers.**

Series map

#	Book	Pain it solves
1–5	Structure / Task 1 / Vocab / Mistakes / Checklist	Core skills
6	Stuck at 6.5 (this book)	Score plateau
7	No Ideas Pack	Blank mind under pressure

Contents

1. Why 6.5 feels endless
 2. The 5 plateau traps
 3. What usually separates 6.5 from 7
 4. One-week repair plan
 5. Before/after paragraph rewrites
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1. Why 6.5 feels endless

At around 6.5, many students:

- write enough words

- use some linking phrases
- avoid total collapse in grammar

...but still:

- answer the question only partly
- repeat the same idea in both body paragraphs
- use "safe" vague vocabulary (*good, bad, important, people think*)
- make the same 5 grammar errors every essay

Plateau truth: more random practice does not raise the score.

Targeted repair does.

2. The 5 plateau traps

Trap 1 — Soft position

There are advantages and disadvantages... and no clear choice when the question asks for one.

Fix: write your position in one blunt sentence in the introduction and repeat it in the conclusion.

Trap 2 — Two paragraphs, one idea

Body 1: online learning is flexible.

Body 2: online learning saves time.

(= same idea twice)

Fix: force two *different* angles (e.g. access + skills, cost + fairness, short-term + long-term).

Trap 3 — Explanation without example

You explain theory but never show a concrete case.

Fix: every body paragraph needs one specific example (school, workplace, city, personal but formal).

Trap 4 — Vocabulary theatre

Rare words used incorrectly to "look Band 7".

Fix: precise common academic words beat broken rare words. See Book 3.

Trap 5 — Editing zero

You finish at minute 40 with no check.

Fix: protect 5 minutes. Plateau students often lose marks on articles, agreement, and task coverage — all editable.

3. What usually separates 6.5 from 7

This is a practical checklist, not an official descriptor copy.

Area	Typical 6.5 pattern	Move toward 7
Task	Position fuzzy / one part weak	Exact answer + clear stance
Ideas	Generic, overlapping	Two distinct, developed ideas
Cohesion	Overused firstly/moreover	Clear paragraph logic
Lexis	Safe + occasional wrong "fancy" word	Natural collocations
Grammar	Frequent small errors	Same range, fewer repeats

One sentence goal:

Clear answer + two developed ideas + fewer repeated mistakes.

4. One-week repair plan

Do **one focus per day**. Do not try to fix everything at once.

Day	Focus	Task
1	Position	Rewrite 3 old intros with a sharp stance
2	Idea split	For 5 prompts, write only 2 non-overlapping ideas
3	Examples	Add one concrete example to each body of one essay
4	Grammar family	Fix only articles + agreement in one essay
5	Timed essay	40 minutes + Book 5 checklist
6	Rewrite	Same essay again after feedback
7	Review	List your personal top 3 repeated errors

Feedback loop: write → check at <https://stratumielts.com> → rewrite once.

5. Before / after paragraph rewrites

Example A — vague → clear

Before (stuck style)

Online education is important for many people because it is good and helpful. It has many

advantages in today's world and students can benefit from it a lot.

After (clearer Band 7 direction)

Online education improves access for students who live far from universities. They can attend lectures without relocating, which reduces cost and travel time. For example, a learner in a small town can complete a degree programme while keeping a local job.

What changed: specific benefit + mechanism + example.

Example B — overlapping ideas → split ideas

Weak plan

1. Technology saves time
2. Technology is faster

Stronger plan

1. Technology increases speed of service delivery
2. Technology creates new skill demands / inequality risks

Same topic, different jobs for each paragraph.

Example C — soft conclusion → locked conclusion

Before

In conclusion, there are both sides and people should decide carefully.

After

In conclusion, I believe governments should invest first in public transport rather than fuel taxes, because it offers a fairer long-term solution.

6. Practice protocol (anti-plateau)

Rule 1 — Fewer essays, more rewrites

2 timed essays + 2 rewrites beat 7 unrewritten drafts.

Rule 2 — Track only your top errors

Make a personal list of 3:

- e.g. articles / no example / unclear position

Every edit pass hunts those three first.

Rule 3 — One upgrade metric per week

Pick one:

- "My position is obvious in 10 seconds"
- "My two ideas do not overlap"
- "I leave 5 minutes to edit"

Rule 4 — Stop collecting tips

If you already know structure, stop watching random advice videos. Execute the week plan.

7. Next step on Stratum IELTS

1. Take your latest essay.
2. Mark which plateau trap it falls into.
3. Rewrite **one** body paragraph using Example A style.
4. Submit both versions to the checker at <https://stratumielts.com>.
5. Compare feedback — keep the stronger pattern.

If your real pain is "I have nothing to write", open **Book 7: No Ideas Pack**.

Quick self-test

Answer Yes/No:

- ☐ My introduction states a clear position
- ☐ Body 1 and Body 2 are different ideas
- ☐ Each body has a concrete example
- ☐ I edit for 5 minutes
- ☐ I rewrite after feedback

0–2 Yes → start Day 1 of the week plan today.

3–4 Yes → focus on your weakest No.

5 Yes → you are ready for harder prompts and consistency.

About this booklet

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